

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRE

Joe's been a scholar, a soldier, a prosecutor, and a philanthropist. This guy is a machine, and he's faced and managed all kinds of risks throughout his life. As a teenager, his parents sent him to a four-year prep school. He didn't want to go at first, but looking back, he knows the work ethic and study habits he developed while going through that rigid academic program set him up for a lifetime of success. Not even law school presented much of a challenge to him compared to what he faced in high school!

Joe studied psychology at Duke University before starting graduate school to prepare for a career in advertising. When he realized most of those ad account executive jobs would require him to move to Chicago or New York, and being frustrated by the high turnover he saw in the advertising world, he decided to change his career goals. The Vietnam War was raging during this time, and Joe knew he'd likely get drafted. To get ahead of the curve, he enrolled in a two-year Army ROTC program in grad school. That way, he thought, he'd at least be able to enter the military as an officer. Graduating in the top 10% of his class, Joe could choose which job in the Army he wanted. He volunteered for the infantry, jump school, and eventually the Army Special Forces. He was ultimately wounded in combat and released from the Army on a medical discharge.

When Joe returned home, he took advantage of the Army's G.I. Bill to pursue a law degree. He began his law career as a prosecutor for the state of Florida, but the bureaucracy and red tape made it hard for him to get ahead and grow his salary. That inspired him to leave his state position and open his own law practice. Not surprisingly, this hardworking soldier grew his practice and his salary quickly. Through it all, though, he never let his spending get out of control. The voice of his father always rang in his ears, "Invest half of what you make, never go into debt, never spend any money you don't have, and you'll be all right." Joe built his financial life around those principles, and it worked for him. Throughout his career, even when he earned well above six figures per year, he made a practice of investing half his income into mutual funds. By keeping his spending in check and faithfully investing so much over many years, Joe was able to retire comfortably at age forty-eight.

He spent the first ten years of his retirement traveling with his wife and doing all the things he wanted to do. Although he has allowed himself some nice things, those extravagances have been few and far between. His wise money management, in fact, has left him in a surprising situation: he doesn't need to use his massive investment accounts to support himself and his wife. His Army pension, combined with his state pension from his years as a Florida prosecutor and a little bit from Social Security, provide him plenty of income to live on each month. "It doesn't cost me much to maintain my lifestyle," he said.

So, if he doesn't need it to live on, what's Joe doing with his nearly \$2.7 million net worth? He's giving it away. Years ago, he set up a private 501(c)(3) foundation to facilitate his outrageous giving. Over the past decade, he's given away \$3.5 million of his personal wealth. With no kids and enough money to comfortably live on, Joe and his wife have set a goal to give away all their wealth before their death. Plus, they donate a huge amount of time doing volunteer work through their foundation and other charities. This guy is a hero in every sense of the word. He's given his time, his money, and even his blood to make this world a better place.
